CENTURIO

EVIDENCE BASED MENTAL FITNESS TRAINING

A PRACTICAL GUIDE TO MENTAL FITNESS

The Six Capacities

Six practices to train the mind the way you train the body.

Sterling Cincotta
Founder of Centurio

Start where it hurts.

Read the six lines below. Pick the one that sounds most like your last fortnight, turn to that page, and run the practice on something real this week.

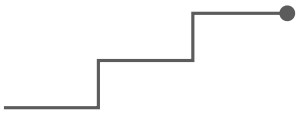
I said I would, and then I did not.	LEAD	03
I am busy, and I am no longer sure it adds up to anything.	ALIGN	04
Something small took me out for three days.	REGULATE	05
The people closest to me are getting the worst of me.	CONNECT	06
I have known this for years and I still have not changed it.	GROW	07
I know exactly what to do and it is still not getting done.	PERFORM	08

One capacity. Seven days. Train one before you add another. The commitment page at the back is where you write it down.

LEAD

Trust Yourself

Leadership begins with the promises you keep to yourself.



When did I last keep a promise I made only to myself?

Self trust is built the same way as any other kind of trust, by a record of things said and then done. Each promise you keep is a small piece of evidence about who you are, and your mind is counting them whether you ask it to or not.

PRACTICE / THE KEPT PROMISE — 5 MINUTES

1. **Name one promise.** Write down one thing you will do this week that nobody else will know about.
2. **Make it small enough to survive a bad day.** If your week falls apart on Wednesday, this still gets done. Shrink it until that is true.
3. **Fix the when and the where.** A promise with no time attached is a wish.
4. **Record it the moment it is done.** One line, one tick. The record is the point, because the evidence is what rebuilds the trust.

IN YOUR WORK

Before you ask your team to hold a standard, find one standard you have let slide yourself and reinstate it this week. They are watching that one, and it carries further than the instruction.

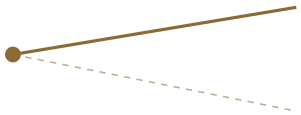
LEADERSHIP EXAMPLE / JAMES CLEAR

James Clear describes habits as votes for the person you want to become. A kept promise is one vote. The number that matters is the running total.

ALIGN

Know Your Direction

Alignment occurs when your actions match your beliefs, values and vision.



BELIEVE DO DRIFT

If my life was a movie, what would the audience be screaming at the screen?

The audience can always see it. From outside, the gap between what somebody says matters and what they actually do is obvious, and it is obvious long before the person living it notices. Drift happens through a hundred reasonable decisions, each one defensible on its own, until the shape of the week stops matching the shape of the life. Your calendar is the honest record of what you actually chose.

PRACTICE / THE CALENDAR AUDIT — 15 MINUTES

1. **Write your three.** Three things that genuinely matter to you right now, in your own words.
2. **Open last fortnight.** Go through it hour by hour and put a mark beside anything that served one of the three.
3. **Total it.** Count the marked hours against the unmarked ones and sit with the number for a minute before you explain it away.
4. **Move one thing.** One recurring block in the next fortnight, moved or removed, so the record starts telling a different story.

IN YOUR WORK

Take the single biggest recurring meeting in your week and ask which of your three it serves. If the honest answer is none of them, that is an hour you have been paying for in the dark.

LEADERSHIP EXAMPLE / SIMON SINEK

Simon Sinek's whole argument is that direction comes before activity. People do not buy what you do, they buy why you do it, and the same is true of the way you spend a Tuesday.

REGULATE

Master Your State

Influence your state to best serve the moment.



REACT SPACE RESPOND

Is this as big as it currently feels?

The moment arrives at a size, and then your state decides what size it becomes. Composure is the practice of putting something between the event and the response, often enough that the gap is there when you need it.

PRACTICE / S.O.U.R.R. 3 MINUTES

1. **Slow.** One longer breath out than in. You are buying a few seconds, nothing more.
2. **Observe.** Name what you are feeling in plain words. Not devastated. A little disappointed.
3. **Understand.** Ask what the feeling is telling you to change. Frustration usually says the approach is not working. Anger usually says a rule of yours was crossed.
4. **Redirect.** Ask what else this could reasonably mean. Find one alternative that fits the same facts.
5. **Respond.** Choose the action, then take it. The practice is finished when something happens.

IN YOUR WORK

Run it in the thirty seconds between reading a message that lands badly and replying to it. That gap is where most of the damage in a working week gets done or avoided.

LEADERSHIP EXAMPLE / MARCUS AURELIUS

Marcus Aurelius wrote that your pain comes from your estimate of a thing, and that the estimate can be revoked at any moment. Written two thousand years ago, and still the mechanism.

CONNECT

Elevate Others

Connection begins when another person feels genuinely seen, heard and understood.



HEAR ASK LIFT

When they told me their good news, what did I actually do with it?

Relationships are built in the ordinary moments far more than the hard ones. How you respond when somebody tells you something good turns out to predict the strength of the relationship better than how you respond when they tell you something bad.

PRACTICE / THE FULL RESPONSE 2 MINUTES

1. **Stop what you are holding.** Put the phone face down and out of reach. An unused phone on the table still says you are partly elsewhere.
2. **Respond with real interest.** Match their energy out loud. A flat “that's great” reads as dismissal, whatever you meant by it.
3. **Ask them to say more.** One genuine question about the part they are most pleased with, then let them talk.
4. **Come back to it later.** Mention it again the next day. That is the move that tells somebody you were actually there.

IN YOUR WORK

Run it the next time somebody on your team brings you a win. The thirty seconds you give it sets what they bring you next time, and whether they bring you anything at all.

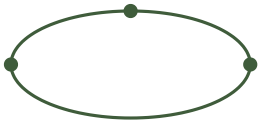
LEADERSHIP EXAMPLE / SHADÉ ZAHRAI

Shadé Zahrai puts it as leaving people better than you found them. It is a standard you can apply to any interaction, including the ones you did not choose.

GROW

Remain Teachable

Growth begins when you remain teachable.



DO REFLECT CHANGE

What have I repeated three times without ever stopping to look at it?

Experience on its own teaches very little. The same fortnight can produce either a lesson or an excuse, and what decides which is whether anybody sat down and looked at it honestly.

PRACTICE / THE FIFTEEN MINUTE REVIEW — 15 MINUTES, WEEKLY

1. **Pick the fortnight, not the day.** Patterns do not show up at close range.
2. **Write what happened.** Facts only, no interpretation yet. What you did, what followed.
3. **Find the repeat.** Something you have now done more than once. Name it without defending it.
4. **Change one input.** Not the goal, not the effort. One thing you feed into the situation next time.

IN YOUR WORK

After the next piece of work that lands badly, book fifteen minutes before you book the next attempt. Going again immediately feels like momentum and usually repeats the thing.

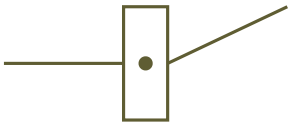
LEADERSHIP EXAMPLE / MARCUS AURELIUS

Marcus Aurelius again: the thing in the way becomes the way. The obstacle is the curriculum, provided somebody actually reads it.

PERFORM

Turn Intention into Action

Performance begins when intention becomes action.



INTEND CUE ACT

What is the exact moment this gets done?

An intention held in general terms waits for a version of you who feels like it. An intention tied to a specific moment runs on the mornings you do not.

PRACTICE / THE IF THEN PLAN 5 MINUTES

1. **Name the one thing.** The single action you have been carrying for more than a week.
2. **Find your usual obstacle.** Be specific and be honest. The real one, the one that actually shows up, not the respectable version.
3. **Write the sentence.** “If it is 6am and I am deciding again, then I put my feet on the floor before I think about it.” If this, then that, with a real cue attached.
4. **Rehearse it once.** Picture the obstacle arriving and picture yourself running the plan. Say it out loud once. Rehearsed plans fire faster than remembered ones.

IN YOUR WORK

Take the decision you have deferred twice and attach it to a cue already in your diary. Not a day. A moment that is definitely going to happen.

LEADERSHIP EXAMPLE / SIMON SINEK

Simon Sinek points out that nobody gets fit from one nine hour session in the gym, and twenty minutes a day gets you there. Consistency outperforms intensity, and it always has.

One capacity. Seven days.

Choose the capacity where a small change would make the biggest difference to your next fortnight. Train that one before you add another.

THE CAPACITY I AM TRAINING

THE PRACTICE I WILL RUN

THE SITUATION I WILL RUN IT IN

WHAT I WILL LOOK FOR AFTER SEVEN DAYS

After seven days, ask what you actually did differently, not how motivated you felt. Judge the behaviour you can observe.

FIND OUT WHICH ONE TO START WITH

The Mental Fitness Score takes three minutes and gives you a number on all six. It names the one you are weakest at right now.
centuriocollective.com/score

Take it again in twelve weeks. The gap between those two sets of numbers is the whole point.

FOR THE CURIOUS

The thinking behind the practices.

These practices adapt established research for daily use. The leadership examples illustrate related principles and do not establish use of these exact techniques. Each research finding comes from its own specific setting and none of them is a validation of this guide as a whole. The Mental Fitness Score is a self assessment, not a validated psychometric test, a diagnosis or an objective measure of mental ability.

RESEARCH

R1 / Bandura (1977)
Self efficacy: toward a unifying theory of behavioral change. *Psychological Review*, 84(2), 191 to 215.

R2 / Cohen and Sherman (2014)
The psychology of change: self affirmation and social psychological intervention. *Annual Review of Psychology*, 65, 333 to 371.

R3 / Gross (1998)
Antecedent and response focused emotion regulation: divergent consequences for experience, expression, and physiology. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 74(1), 224 to 237.

R4 / Gable, Reis, Impett and Asher (2004)
What do you do when things go right? The intrapersonal and interpersonal benefits of sharing positive events. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 87(2), 228 to 245.

R5 / Di Stefano, Gino, Pisano and Staats (2014)
Learning by thinking: how reflection can spur progress along the learning curve. *Harvard Business School Working Paper 14 093*.

R6 / Gollwitzer (1999)
Implementation intentions: strong effects of simple plans. *American Psychologist*, 54, 493 to 503.

THE CATEGORY ITSELF

R7 / Robinson, Oades and Caputi (2015)
Conceptualising and measuring mental fitness: a Delphi study. *International Journal of Wellbeing*, 5(1).

> An international panel of twenty five experts reached consensus that mental fitness can be understood in the same way as physical fitness, that it can be measured, and that it can be improved. That is the premise Centurio is built on, and it was settled in the literature before we started.

THINKERS REFERENCED

James Clear, on habits as votes for an identity.

Simon Sinek, on direction before activity, and on consistency over intensity.

Marcus Aurelius, on the estimate of a thing, and on the obstacle becoming the way.

Shadé Zahrai, on leaving people better than you found them.